WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

THAILAND

Asia East

Information current as of October 2026

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office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Bangkok	Capital and commercial centre; seat of government, the Bank of Thailand and the Stock Exchange of Thailand, and the main regional headquarters location	Financial services, digital services, retail, real estate, healthcare
Eastern Economic Corridor (Chachoengsao, Chonburi, Rayong)	Flagship investment zone under its own EEC Act, with around 200 EV-related investment applications worth 140 billion baht logged	EVs and automotive, electronics, petrochemicals, digital infrastructure
Laem Chabang Port (Chonburi)	Thailand's principal deep-sea container port; Phase 3 expansion will lift capacity to nearly 18 million TEU and raise rail's share of freight	Port logistics, warehousing, export manufacturing
U-Tapao (Rayong)	Airport city project whose 50-year concession received its Notice to Proceed in April 2026, with a first phase of 3 million passengers and ultimate capacity of 60 million	Aviation, MRO, high-value tourism, logistics
Central region data-centre cluster	Centre of the 2026 investment surge, with digital projects worth $33 billion among H1 2026 applications and national data-centre demand approaching 30,000 MW	Data centres, cloud services, power and renewable energy
Northern Thailand (Chiang Mai and region)	Fastest-growing investment region in H1 2026, with application values up 93% year-on-year	Agro-processing, tourism, creative and digital industries
Phuket and the southern tourism belt	Core destinations for a tourism sector that generated over 1 trillion baht from 20.8 million foreign visitors in January–August 2026	Hospitality, wellness, aviation, property

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Board of Investment (BOI), the national investment promotion agency, offers tax incentives, land-ownership and foreign-ownership permissions and work-permit support for promoted projects, with Thailand FastPass speeding implementation
- Investment Promotion Act framework, under which BOI-promoted companies can obtain exemptions from Foreign Business Act restrictions and incentive packages tailored to targeted industries

- Eastern Economic Corridor Office, administering the EEC Act with dedicated incentives, one-stop permitting and infrastructure concessions in the three eastern provinces
- Foreign Business Act licensing route for non-promoted activities; US investors may also use the US–Thailand Treaty of Amity for national treatment in most sectors
- Bank of Thailand oversight of the managed-floating baht; profits, dividends and capital may be repatriated with supporting documentation through commercial banks
- Public–private partnership concessions for transport, airport, port and utility projects, including the EEC flagship infrastructure programme
- Long-Term Resident (LTR) visa and Smart Visa programmes for investors, executives and skilled professionals

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Thailand in October 2026 is in the midst of its strongest investment cycle in more than a decade. Board of Investment applications reached $43.6 billion in H1 2026, up 37% year-on-year, with foreign applications up 80% to $40.5 billion, led by data centres and cloud services ($33 billion) and followed by electronics, food processing and logistics. This followed record FDI inflows of $19.1 billion in 2025, up 30%. Real private investment grew 13.4% in Q2 2026, its fastest pace since 2012, and goods exports rose 17.6% on demand for electronics and high-tech products. GDP grew 2.4% in 2025 and 2.8% and 1.9% in the first two quarters of 2026, with the NESDC raising its 2026 forecast to 2.0–2.5%. Macroeconomic buffers are substantial: net international reserves exceed $300 billion, covering short-term external debt 2.8 times, inflation is moderate at 2.82% in September and the policy rate stands at 1.00%.

Thailand's main structural task is to spread the gains of the export- and investment-led upswing to domestic demand. Private consumption growth eased to 1.9% in Q2 2026, reflecting high household debt and tighter lending to SMEs, while public debt of around 68% of GDP sits close to the 70% ceiling, limiting room for fiscal stimulus. The authorities are responding with a stable, accommodative monetary stance, measured borrowing that keeps debt within the ceiling, OECD-accession reforms targeted for completion by 2028 and policies to deepen local supply chains. For investors, this means the strongest opportunities lie in the high-growth, outward-facing segments — digital infrastructure, electronics, EVs and logistics — and in the productivity, automation and financial-inclusion solutions that will help broaden growth across the economy.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
US trade policy and tariffs	Thai goods currently face a 12.5% US Section 301 tariff, while a US–Thailand Agreement on Reciprocal Trade is in final-stage negotiation; US trade still rose 42% in January–August 2026	Monitor the agreement's final terms, document origin and supply-chain compliance carefully, and position for continued strong US demand for Thai electronics
Thailand–Cambodia border situation	Land crossings have remained closed since June 2025 after border clashes in July and December 2025; a ceasefire was agreed on 27 December 2025	Exposure is concentrated in cross-border trade and border provinces; route regional supply chains via ports and other land borders and monitor normalisation steps
Household debt and soft consumption	High household debt and contracting SME lending have slowed private consumption to 1.9% growth in Q2 2026	Focus on export-, investment- and tourism-driven segments, and on fintech, financial-inclusion and productivity solutions that support domestic recovery
Foreign ownership restrictions	The Foreign Business Act limits foreign participation in a range of service and other activities without a licence	Obtain BOI promotion or EEC privileges, which can grant majority or full foreign ownership; US investors can use the Treaty of Amity
Limited fiscal space	Public debt is projected at about 68% of GDP at end-FY2026 and just over 69% in FY2027, close to the 70% ceiling	Public–private partnerships are a growing channel for infrastructure delivery, creating openings for private capital and operators
Energy prices and currency movements	Middle East conflict and shifting US rate expectations have made energy prices	Apply standard currency hedging; rising energy costs strengthen the case for

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	and the baht more volatile in 2026, although bond yields have stayed broadly stable	investment in renewables and energy efficiency
Pace of flagship infrastructure delivery	The high-speed rail link between Bangkok's three airports remains delayed, although U-Tapao and Laem Chabang Phase 3 are advancing	Base logistics plans on motorway and port capacity already in place, and engage early on PPP opportunities as projects are restructured

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Thailand's risk profile is that of a mature, well-buffered emerging economy attracting record investment. Net reserves above $300 billion, moderate inflation, stable bond markets and a central bank with room to support growth give a strong macroeconomic foundation, while the new government formed by Prime Minister Anutin Charnvirakul after the February 2026 election has a clear mandate and an experienced economic team. The main issues for investors are external and cyclical: US tariff arrangements, which are close to being settled through a reciprocal trade agreement; the Thailand–Cambodia border, where a ceasefire has been in place since December 2025 but land crossings have stayed closed; and energy-price volatility linked to the Middle East. Domestically, high household debt and limited fiscal headroom are moderating consumption and public spending. None of these has slowed the investment cycle, and investors who use BOI promotion, sound legal structuring and standard currency hedging will find Thailand a dependable base for regional operations.

MARKET ACCESS

Thailand is a founding member of ASEAN and a WTO member since 1995, and participates in the ASEAN Free Trade Area and the Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP), giving tariff-preferential access to the wider Asia-Pacific region. The United States is its largest export market, with bilateral trade reaching $84.2 billion in January–August 2026, up 42%, and an Agreement on Reciprocal Trade in final-stage negotiation. Europe is a growing frontier: Thailand has ratified its first European free trade agreement, with EFTA, and FTA talks with the EU, its fourth-largest trading partner with $45 billion of trade in 2025, are in their final stretch with both sides aiming to conclude in 2026. China, Japan and ASEAN neighbours are central to supply chains, and Laem Chabang and the EEC's road, rail and air links make Thailand a natural manufacturing and logistics hub for mainland Southeast Asia.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the Prime Minister (Anutin Charnvirakul)	Leads the Bhumjaithai-led coalition government formed after the February 2026 election and sets economic, trade and investment priorities	Primary reference point for Thailand's strategic direction and major investment initiatives
Board of Investment (BOI)	National investment promotion agency granting incentives and ownership privileges; recorded $43.6 billion of applications in H1 2026	Standard first point of contact for market entry, incentives and FastPass facilitation
Eastern Economic Corridor Office	Administers the EEC Act, the flagship zone's incentives and its airport, port and rail infrastructure concessions	Key partner for manufacturing, EV, logistics and infrastructure investment in the east
Bank of Thailand (Governor Vitai Ratanakorn)	Monetary authority; sets the policy rate (1.00%), manages the baht and supervises banks	Relevant for currency, repatriation and banking-sector matters
Ministry of Finance (Minister Ekniti Nitithanprapas)	Leads fiscal and tax policy, public debt management and state-enterprise oversight	Relevant for tax incentives, PPP financing and fiscal-policy direction
Ministry of Commerce	Leads trade negotiations, including the US reciprocal trade agreement and EU FTA,	Key interlocutor on market access and foreign-ownership licensing

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
	and administers Foreign Business Act licensing	
Ministry of Foreign Affairs	Leads diplomacy with the US, China, ASEAN partners and Cambodia, and coordinates Thailand's OECD accession	Relevant for geopolitical positioning, regional relations and reform trajectory

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Joint Foreign Chambers of Commerce in Thailand brings together the main foreign chambers, including the American Chamber of Commerce, the British Chamber of Commerce Thailand, the European Association for Business and Commerce and the Japanese Chamber of Commerce, Bangkok. The Thai Chamber of Commerce and the Federation of Thai Industries are the principal domestic business bodies. The BOI runs regular investor seminars and overseas roadshows, and the EEC Office hosts investor briefings with foreign chambers. The World Bank, Asian Development Bank and IFC remain active in infrastructure, green finance and private-sector development, and Bangkok's role as a regional hub for international organisations makes it an effective base for regional networking.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Thailand suits investors seeking a stable, well-connected manufacturing and services base in Southeast Asia: digital-infrastructure and cloud investors drawn by large-scale data-centre demand; electronics, PCB and semiconductor-related manufacturers diversifying regional supply chains; EV and automotive investors building on an established automotive cluster in the EEC; and food-processing, logistics and healthcare investors serving domestic and regional markets. Hospitality and wellness investors benefit from a tourism sector earning over 1 trillion baht in eight months, while renewable-energy and infrastructure investors can find openings through PPP concessions and rising corporate demand for clean power.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage the BOI early on promotion and FastPass
Open dialogue with the Board of Investment to confirm sector incentives, foreign-ownership privileges and FastPass facilitation before finalising structure and location.

STEP 2: Assess the Eastern Economic Corridor for industrial and logistics projects
Compare EEC Act privileges and infrastructure access, including Laem Chabang and U-Tapao, with BOI packages available elsewhere in the country.

STEP 3: Structure ownership with specialist legal advice
Map activities against the Foreign Business Act and use BOI promotion, EEC privileges or the US Treaty of Amity where relevant.

STEP 4: Track trade agreements and tariff outcomes
Follow the conclusion of the US reciprocal trade agreement and the EU FTA, and build origin and compliance requirements into export planning.

STEP 5: Plan for currency, energy and regional logistics
Apply standard baht hedging, secure long-term power supply including renewables, and route regional flows through ports and open land borders.